LEONARDO DA VINCI by Georgia Clarke
(B1–B2)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *Leonardo da Vinci* by Georgia Clarke in which Ss read and listen to the stories behind two of da Vinci's famous portraits. Ss find out more about da Vinci's works and learn some anatomy terms.

Supplementary Materials

WARM UP: a picture of the painting of *Ginevra di Benci* by Leonardo da Vinci, large enough for Ss to make out details in the background.

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION: internet access OR the **Pearson English eReader** *Leonardo da Vinci*.

SPEAKOUT: internet access OR the **Pearson English eReader** *Leonardo da Vinci*.

CLIL CONNECTION: internet access; (optional) a basic diagram of the human body, perhaps just an outline for Ss to draw bones and muscles on.

Culture notes

Leonardo da Vinci
The epitome of the Renaissance in the fifteenth century, Leonardo da Vinci was famous for his knowledge of and interests in architecture, sculpture, invention, engineering, science, mathematics and astronomy among others. In particular, he is famous for his paintings of *Mona Lisa* and *The Last Supper* and the sketch *Vitruvian Man* that is often in anatomy textbooks.

Leonardo the portrait artist
Portraits were very popular at this time and Leonardo was famous for painting very life-like images of people. The *Mona Lisa* may be his most famous portrait but it was not his only one. One of Leonardo's earliest portraits is of *Ginevra de' Benci*, the daughter of a very rich Florentine, who was much admired for her beauty and intelligence. Another portrait, *The Lady with an Ermine*, shows Cecilia Gallerani, who was the lover of Ludovico Sforza, the most powerful man in Milan.

WARM UP

Show Ss the painting but do not say who it is, or name the artist. Ask if they know anything about it or can guess anything. Note ideas but do not confirm anything. Leave the picture on display and say they will find out more during the lesson. As you begin the lesson, Ss will probably quickly ask if it is a painting by Leonardo da Vinci. You can confirm it is but do not say anything else.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see, think, wonder

Focus Ss on the picture of the *Mona Lisa*. They can probably easily identify the work and the artist. Then divide Ss into pairs and allow time for them to discuss the questions in *see*, *think* and *wonder*. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed and make a note of anything useful on the board to go over at feedback stage. In feedback, elicit ideas briefly as a class.

ANSWERS:

see

1 Ss' description of the woman's face, hair and clothes.

2 Ss' description may include the colours, trees and water.

think

3 Probably only very rich, important people, especially the nobility.

4 People with money but a wider variety than just nobility, e.g. celebrities.

wonder

5 Ss' own answers based on the painting of what kind of character and social position she might have had.

COMPREHENSION

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the title and ask *What other things was Leonardo da Vinci famous for?* (See Culture notes for ideas.) If they do not volunteer it, draw their attention to the painting at the bottom of the left hand page and ask what it is (*The Last Supper)*. Tell them they are going to learn about two of Leonardo's well known portraits.

READING EXTRACT LL7.01

Allow time for Ss to read in silence, or play the recording so they can listen and read. When they have finished, ask how the this painting compares to the *Mona Lisa* and their answers in the Thinking Routine (e.g. the lady is from the nobility and of high social status; there is nature in the background and the *sfumato* technique and colours are similar; people find both women beautiful).

If they do not realise the painting you showed them earlier is the one that the reading extract talks about, draw their attention to it again, without saying anything, perhaps just moving it from one place on the wall to another, for example, and see if anyone realises it is the same painting. If they do not realise, move on to the Comprehension.

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2 LL7.01 **Books closed. Write the Question stem from question 1 on the board. See if Ss can remember the answer. Do not confirm at this stage. Then with books open, Ss read Question 1 and the options. Ask if any of the options match their initial answer. Tell them instincts can be correct but they must look for evidence in the text. Elicit the correct answer (c) and the place in the text that supports that conclusion. (Lines 1–2 say he was famous for making portraits that people recognised.)**

Allow Ss time to read and answer the rest of the questions. Get feedback as a class and check the answers. Ask Ss to supply the line from the text that supported their ideas, even if they offer the wrong answer, as it helps them see where they went wrong.

ANSWERS:

1 c **2** b and d

Teaching tip

With multiple-choice questions, encourage Ss to make good guesses when they're working out the answer. If one or two of the options are obviously wrong, they can cross them off and then they have a 50/50 chance of being right if there are two options left. If they can support their choice with the text, they have a very good chance of getting the answer right.

Draw Ss attention to the painting again, if no one has noticed by themselves ask *Does this painting look familiar yet?* You could point out things in the background like the plants and the way she looks out at us from the painting. If they still don't make the connection, tell them!

LISTENING

3 LL7.02 **Tell Ss they're going to hear about another portrait, the one of the woman in the bottom of the right hand page. Focus on the glossary words in the box and make sure Ss have noted the meaning, before listening. Give Ss time to read the questions and then play the recording twice for Ss to choose the correct answer.**

LL7.02 AUDIOSCRIPT

The Lady with an **Ermine**. This painting shows Cecilia Gallerani. She was the lover of Ludovico Sforza, the most powerful man in Milan. Leonardo's skill in this portrait was to bring her to life for us. She turns to her left. Has she heard or seen someone or something? Her position is natural and her rich clothes also have natural forms. This sense of life in a painting was something that Leonardo thought was really important. He wrote that a good painting of a person is one where 'the behaviour of the person in the picture shows the energy that is inside them.'

The animal in Cecilia's arms is an ermine. Leonardo wrote that the ermine:

prefers to let itself be caught by hunters instead of entering a dirty place to save itself. This is because it does not want to mark its pure nature.

The whiteness of the ermine's fur is a **symbol** of **purity**. The ermine here shows that Cecilia had a clean and perfect character.

Cecilia's portrait by Leonardo was famous. In April 1498 Isabella d'Este, the sister of Ludovico Sforza's wife Beatrice, wrote to Cecilia to ask her if she would lend it to her. Isabella had just seen some beautiful portraits by the Venetian painter Giovanni Bellini, and she wanted to compare his work with Leonardo's.

Cecilia sent the painting immediately. She wrote, though, that she would be happier to send the painting if it looked more like her: *But this is not because of any fault in the great painter himself – I truly believe there is no painter equal to him – but only because the portrait was painted when I was very young. I have changed completely since then.*

ANSWERS:

1 b **2** a

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

4 **Focus Ss on the questions. Allow time for them to research the answers, either online or using the full Pearson English eReader of Leonardo da Vinci (see Supplementary materials). Check answers as a whole class.**

ANSWERS:

1 5th April 1452 at about 10:30 p.m.; 2nd May 1519

2 He brought together many different ideas and knowledge because he was also a sculptor and architect, sang and played musical instruments, and he was interested in nature, science and mathematics.

3 The Mona Lisa, painted sometime between 1503 and 1506.

4 It was to be out of bronze but after he spent a long time making the clay model, there was a war with France and all the bronze was needed for guns. The French soldiers destroyed the clay model when they took control of Milan.

5 Various answers possible; flying machine with wings, helicopters, parachutes, an armoured car like a tank, an alarm clock, a robot, scuba diving equipment.

6 In 1962, someone threw a bottle of ink at the painting in London's National Gallery. In 1987, someone shot it.

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SPEAKING

5 **Focus on the words in the box. Write the words on the board and elicit any information the Ss already know on the topics. Alternatively, divide the class into small groups and let them brainstorm the topics and what they already know on paper. They then choose one of the topics, either individually or in their groups, to do more research on. Allow time for them to research online, or from the full Pearson English eReader and make notes. Rearrange Ss so they are in groups of four, each person with a different topic to report back on.**

Ss tell their group what they've learned. Ask them to make note of any questions they might have as they listen to the others in the group. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. At the end, set the questions as homework for Ss to research further, perhaps using the internet.

ANSWERS:

The Last Supper: One of his most famous paintings, a fresco in the Monastery of Santa Maria delle Grazie which has lost some of its details over time. He painted each man looking and behaving differently to show what they were thinking. It was repaired between 1977 and 1999 at a cost of over $9 million. Only 400 people a day are allowed to see it, in groups of not more than 25 for just 15 minutes to control the air quality in the room.

Michelangelo: A contemporary/competitor of da Vinci's. Leonardo was on the committee that decided where the statue of David should go. They both worked on wall paintings in the Palazzo della Signoria around the same time. Neither can be seen today as they were destroyed, Michelangelo's in 1516 and da Vinci's by the mid 1500s.

King Francois I: In August 1516, Leonardo was invited by the French king to be the 'King's Painter' and he was given a house to live in, in Clos Lucé in Amboise, where he died. He was paid well and did a lot of interesting projects for the king, including designing a castle and its gardens. The king admired Leonardo so much he rarely spent time away from him.

Francesco Melzi: Leonardo's assistant and friend from the age of 13 or 14. He helped him with painting and with writing things down. In France, with Leonardo, Francesco was described as 'the Italian gentleman who is with Leonardo' and he was paid 400 écus a year by the French – four times as much as Salai, another assistant. Francesco helped Leonardo in his studies and Leonardo valued him a lot. Francesco's feelings about Leonardo are clear from his will (he left him all his books, painting equipment, portraits, his clothes and his money in France) and the letter he wrote to Leonardo's eldest half-brother on Leonardo's death: *He was like the best father to me, I cannot say how much pain his death gave me. As long as I live, I will always be sad.*

CLIL CONNECTION

Biology

6 **Focus Ss on the words in the box and note the pronunciation of any unfamiliar words. (phalanges: fuh-**lan**-jeez; scapula: **skap**-yuh-luh; tibia: **tib**-ee-uh; mandible: **man**-duh-buh l; sartorius: sahr-tawr-ee-uh s; deltoid: **del**-toyd; Achilles tendon: uh-**kil**-eez **ten**-dun; supinator: **soo-puh-ney-ter)**

Alternative approach

Ss guess how the words are pronounced and then type the words into a speaking dictionary, or online dictionary which has audio versions of words, to check they have the pronunciation correct.

Ask them to use their own knowledge to say which ones are muscle and which are bones and then allow time for them to research online, either at home or in class, to see if they were right. You could extend the activity to finding out which part of the body each one is from. Or, have them draw and label a diagram of the body (see Supplementary materials).

ANSWERS:

Bones: phalanges (hand/foot); scapula (shoulder); tibia (lower leg); mandible (lower face/jaw).

Muscles: sartorius (upper leg); deltoid (shoulder); Achilles tendon (foot); supinator (lower arm).

Homework ideas

- Ss write a letter to Leonardo to persuade him to do a portrait of them.
- Research and answer the questions gathered from Speakout (see above).

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